

Project 4

Course Code and Name: GEF1202 Advanced English Writing Skills

Project Name: Jamdani Sarees: A Journey Through the History and Artistry of Bengal's Handloom Weaving Tradition

Project Type: Feature Writing

Project Theme: Resource Mobilization

Semester of Submission: Spring 2023

Project Description:

This project is a feature article about Jamdani sarees, one of the most valuable traditional handloom products of Bangladesh. The article explores the history, cultural importance, and unique weaving techniques of Jamdani. It also highlights why Jamdani is recognized by UNESCO and how it represents the rich heritage and identity of Bangladesh. The purpose of this feature was to inform readers about the beauty and value of this traditional craft and the importance of preserving it.

Project Justification:

Jamdani is an important part of Bangladesh's culture and history, but many people know very little about its origin and significance. This project was carried out to promote awareness of our traditional handloom industry and encourage people to appreciate and protect this valuable cultural heritage. It also highlights the contribution of local weavers and the importance of supporting traditional craftsmanship.



Feature Writing

GEF1202

Advanced English Writing Skills

Spring 2023

Section 2

"Jamdani Sarees: A Journey Through the History and Artistry of Bengal's Handloom Weaving Tradition"

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"Jamdani Sarees: A Journey Through the History and Artistry of Bengal's Handloom Weaving Tradition"

About the topic:

Sarees are an integral part of Bengali cultural heritage. Women in the Indian subcontinent have been wearing sarees since BC. However, the name and style of wearing were different and women from different regions of the Indian subcontinent have been wearing sarees differently since ancient times. All the name sarees available in the market these days are actually what we call or known as Jamdani, Benarasi, Katan etc. Jamdani is basically a type of muslin. In most cases it refers to the saree, but in fact traditional patterned veils, kurtas, turbans, handkerchiefs, veils all fall under Jamdani. Although today Jamdani is made in various places, Dhaka is considered to be its original birthplace. UNESCO has declared the specific jamdani weaving method as a special unique cultural thing. Also UNESCO recognized Jamdani as a Geographical Indication (GI) product of Bangladesh in 2016. Jamdani is considered a pride product of Bangladesh. Jamdani sarees are handwoven using traditional techniques that have been passed down for generations, and they are highly prized for their intricate designs and high quality. The production of Jamdani sarees is a significant part of Bangladesh's cultural heritage, and the craft is recognized both domestically and internationally. The Bangladesh government has also taken initiatives to promote Jamdani sarees by providing support to weavers and organizing exhibitions to showcase their work. Overall, Jamdani is a source of pride and identity for Bangladesh, and it holds an important place in the country's history and culture.

Objective of the feature:

Through this feature, the Bengali tradition of Jamdani sarees will be highlighted, so that Jamdani sarees, their technical structure, design, history can be highlighted. Bengali girls have been wearing sarees in different ways since the early times, their first choice in clothing is saree and if it is Jamdani then there is no question to refuse. Here the audience will get an idea about the history of Jamdani, the technique of making Jamdani, the work of the Tatis', the design of Jamdani etc.

- Introduction to jamdani saree.
- To know about History and Analysis of Jamdani Saree Naming.

- To know about History of jamdani Saree in the Mughal Period.
- To know about jamdani saree weaving technique design structure.
- To know about the current financial status of jamdani sarees.



Photo credit :<https://www.globaltimes.cn/page/202208/1274274.shtml>

There is a proverb in Bengali, "Women in saree". The first choice of women in Bengali clothing is saree, starting from wedding ceremonies, whether it is Pohela Baisakh, spring festival or Barsa Mangol ,Baro Parban of Bengal, women wear saree. Muslin, cotton, silk, benarasi, and jamdani sarees have all been valued in this Bengal since ancient times. However, the preference for jamdani sarees varies among Bengali women.

Jamdani saree is a type of handloom saree made from cotton, which originated in Bengal, India, and is now also produced in Bangladesh. It is known for its intricate designs that are created by adding additional threads to the warp and weft of the fabric. The additional threads are typically made of fine cotton, silk, or gold and silver threads, and are woven into the fabric to create intricate

patterns, often depicting floral and geometric motifs. The weaving process is time-consuming and requires a high level of skill, making Jamdani sarees highly prized and often expensive. Jamdani sarees are typically lightweight and sheer, making them ideal for warm climates. The cultural history of Bengalis is not complete without sarees. Since the first century BC, women have worn sarees all over the Indian subcontinent. However, the term and method of design varying, and women from various parts of the Indian subcontinent have been wearing sarees in various ways since ancient. Most of the sarees sold under different names now are actually what we refer to as Jamdani, Benarasi, Katan, etc. Basically, jamdani is a kind of muslin. Most often, it refers to the saree, although Jamdani also includes traditional patterned veils, kurtas, turbans, handkerchiefs, and veils. Even though Jamdani is now produced all over the world, Dhaka is still seen as the city where it first originated. The particular jamdani weaving technique has been recognized by UNESCO as a unique cultural heritage. The name of Jamdani comes from the Persian word 'Jamdani'. Jamdani, which is Persian for "booty cloth," comes from the words "Jam" (cloth) and "Dana" (booty). Jamdani is therefore thought to have been introduced and disseminated over the Indian subcontinent by Muslims. However, there are many theories about its naming, like another, in Persian, 'Jam' means a kind of excellent wine and 'Dani' means cup. The name Jamdani derives from the muslin worn by Iranian sakis who served jam. According to the design, Jamdani has different names like Tercha, Jalpar, Panna Hazar, Corolla, Dublajal, Saburga, Boliyar, Shapla Phul, Angurlata, Mayurpachpar, Baghanli, Kalmilta, Chandrapur, Jhumka, Butidar, Jhalar, Mayurpakha, Piulita, Kalkapar, Kachupata, Butterfly, Jasmine, HansaBalaka, Shabnam, Jhumka, Jabaful etc.



Photo credit: <https://www.bproperty.com/blog/motifs-dhakai-jamdani/>

The cut of the yarn decides how fine the Jamdani muslin is. Early in the morning is the best time to spin yarn because the humidity is at its greatest level. Spindles, bamboo baskets, conch shells, and stone bowls were all used by weavers. The weavers used to starch and dye the yarn before weaving jamdani. The color of flowers and forest leaves were applied as color, and straw, rice, or barley was used as rice. Jamdani sarees are handwoven using fine cotton yarn, and the number of yarns used in the weaving process can vary depending on the complexity of the design. Generally, Jamdani sarees are woven with a minimum of two and a maximum of six cotton yarns. The additional threads used to create the intricate designs are typically made of fine cotton, silk, or gold and silver threads, and are woven into the fabric along with the base yarns. The weaving process requires a high level of skill and attention to detail, as the additional threads must be carefully integrated into the fabric to create the desired design.

The history of Jamdani saree can be traced back to the Mughal era in India, particularly in the Dhaka region of Bengal (now Bangladesh). Today, Jamdani sarees continue to be produced in Bangladesh, particularly in the Dhaka and Tangail regions, using traditional weaving techniques that have been passed down through generations of weavers. The Jamdani and Muslin textiles were well known in Dhaka SonarGaon, Dhamrai, and Bajitpur. The craft is recognized both domestically and internationally as a significant cultural heritage of Bangladesh.



Photo credit: <https://www.globaltimes.cn/page/202208/1274274.shtml>

Jamdani is first mentioned in Kautilya's Arthashastra, which was written in 300 AD, in Periplus of the Erythrean Sea, and in the travel and trade documents written by many Arab, Chinese, and Italian individuals. The 'Arthashastra' is a text written by the ancient Indian philosopher Kautilya. Kautilya mentions a certain kind of fine fabric factory in the ancient cities of Banga and Pundre (modern-day Bogra) in that work, which was published around 300 AD. In Dhaka, the Mughal era is referred to as the "golden age of muslin." At this period, both domestically and internationally, demand for muslin and jamdani increased, and the industry grew greatly. High-ranking royal employees with the title of Daroga-i-Malmal were reportedly hired to gather muslins known as Malmal Khas and Sarkar-i-Ali, according to English sources from the eighteenth century. The expert weavers, nardias, ripukas, and other artisans were registered in each loom's office. Daroga's major responsibility was to supervise all of the methods involved in manufacturing muslin and jamdani. At that time, Dhaka exported to the Mughal court silks worth about one lakh rupees. In the Muslim Middle Ages, the Jamdani saree really began to advance. The Jamdani saree is basically a result of the blending of Mughal and Persian civilizations, which the Bengali soil's fertility provided. "During the Mughal era, Jamdani saree quality in East Bengal reached its highest point. In reality, Mughal-Persian art had a major impact on the beautiful patterns on silk fabrics. Jamdani was born and raised in the area of the Dhaka district in what is now Bangladesh.



Photo credit: <https://weaverstory.com/products/hand-woven-linen-jamdani-saree-in-offwhite-and-black>

The use of floral muslin started from the time of Mughal Emperor Jahangir. Jamdani's color, weaving, and design must have changed over time. Lal Jamdani, for example, came to fame in the 1960s. The geometric decoration is a trademark of Jamdani design. Not on paper were the designs drawn. Talented crafters created designs from memory. An account of jamdani and muslim in the middle of the 19th century indicates that the Nawabs of Delhi, Lakshmau Nepal, Murshidabad, etc. used the 50,000 rupee jamdani of flower work on white ground. The Industrial Revolution in England was one of the many variables that caused the decline and then giving way of this industry. This opened the way for the introduction of automating in the textile sector and the reasonable production of printed cloth.

Jamdani weaving instruction is provided by a skilled craftsman or a moneylender to jamdani saree weavers. Along with learning, the descendants of weavers learn it naturally from older generations. The need for this delicate cloth has increased considerably since the covid epidemic. On social media, customers favor ornas, punjabis, two-pieces, and jamdani sarees. People are used to shopping online as a result of internet businesses. Many women started working in the online garment industry during the shutdown, which greatly expanded the demand for Jamdani goods. In addition, a change in fashion is apparent. Weddings now have a higher demand for jamdani sarees. Weavers are therefore needed all year long. Weavers, meanwhile, gripe that their per-saree pay has remained the same in the past despite rising commodity prices.

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Learnings and Outcomes (Self-reflection):

- Learned how to write a feature article in an informative and engaging style.
- Gained knowledge about the history, cultural value, and weaving process of Jamdani sarees.
- Improved my research, writing, and storytelling skills.
- Understood the importance of preserving Bangladesh's cultural heritage and traditional crafts.